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One for the Road

Call them work buddies or play mates—the new generation of mobile devices will make you forget about pixellated screens, skimpy applications and arcane user interfaces

With your assortment of portable devices—a PDA, a smart phone, a digital diary—you think you are the king of computing on the go, but you often wish that you could do more with these devices. That you could play more than chess or do more than read an e-book or listen to MP3 music when you are bored with that in-flight movie. That you could go beyond just light editing of your Word and Excel files on your PDA. That you wouldn't miss your laptop so much.

Handheld devices already let you take notes, schedule your day, catch up on e-mail messages or plug in headphones to listen to MP3s during your daily jog. You can even use them as a stand-in for times when you cannot or don't want to take your laptop with you. But they fall just short of being the complete companion for your computing needs on the road.

This void for a portable device that is somewhere between a laptop and a desktop in its computing power and is still small, is being filled by a slew of futuristic portable computers. These new devices incorporate technologies that

integrate several functions into an all-in-one device that is also easy to use.

Take a tablet

You are on the way to work when the perfect idea for that new advertising campaign flashes in your mind. You flip out your PDA and tap in the idea before you lose it. It is cumbersome because the keyboard is cramped and the handwriting recognition software is rather basic. You'd rather jot your idea on a sheet of paper, but then you think that's a small price for the convenience of having your jottings in a digital format.

Take heart. The next generation of Smart Phones and PDAs is going to do something your mother can't—read your handwriting and understand what you're saying! Featuring handwriting and speech processing capabilities, these devices will be able to take down dictations and decipher little notes that you jot down and convert them into a digital format on the fly.

One such device is the tablet PC. First seen on the initial episodes of *Star Trek*, what was once a far-fetched idea is now manifesting into a practical gadget. It offers the most natural way to get information into a device—by writing directly onto it. Quite like a digital slate, this device can be carried around without the slightest inconvenience and used for scribbling down your ideas and diagrams.

Slightly larger than the A4 notepad in size, tablet PCs incorporate advanced speech and handwriting recognition technologies that decipher your scrawl as you write on the screen, while simul-

taneously converting it into a searchable and editable digital format. An appeal to the professional in you, me, it features specially modified versions of Microsoft Word and PowerPoint letting you make notes in the margins, the screen and save them as document references.

Acer's Travelmate 100 is one sub-notebook that can be converted to a tablet PC by simply swivelling its screen 180 degrees and folding it back down its keyboard. It features Microsoft's Windows XP Professional that incorporates support for a touch screen and stylus. Numerous other brands such as Toshiba, Fujitsu, NEC and Hewlett-Packard are bringing out devices based on this technology. The Fujitsu Siemens LT P-600, for example, is powered by a 600 MHz mobile processor and features an LCD screen that can be detached from the base station for true mobility. It also features a Smart Card port that saves your data when the device is not in use.

A more popular tablet computer is Microsoft's own Tablet PC, which runs Windows Tablet PC OS. It mimics the look of a pen and paper. The entire screen is pressure sensitive—pressing the screen harder causes bolder screen strokes with a pencil. And to erase your work, simply flip the stylus around and use it away! There's even a digital journal that allows you to scribble on an interface that resembles a journal page—and your jottings are completely searchable for reference, all on the fly!

The 'Digital Ink' is so versatile and interoperable that you can select

“ In 2001, only 3 per cent of the 111 million mobile-phone subscribers in America used a mobile data service but by 2006, 66 per cent of the 180 million mobile phone users will rely on data services ”

—Forrester Research